

VOL. 7
NEW
DELHI,
INDIA

THE VOICE EXPRESS

The Truth Takes Time.

APRIL 2026
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FROM THE EDITORS Welcome to the April 2026 edition of Voice Express. Our correspondents bring you the stories that matter — from frontlines of policy to quiet revolutions in culture and science.

POLITICS

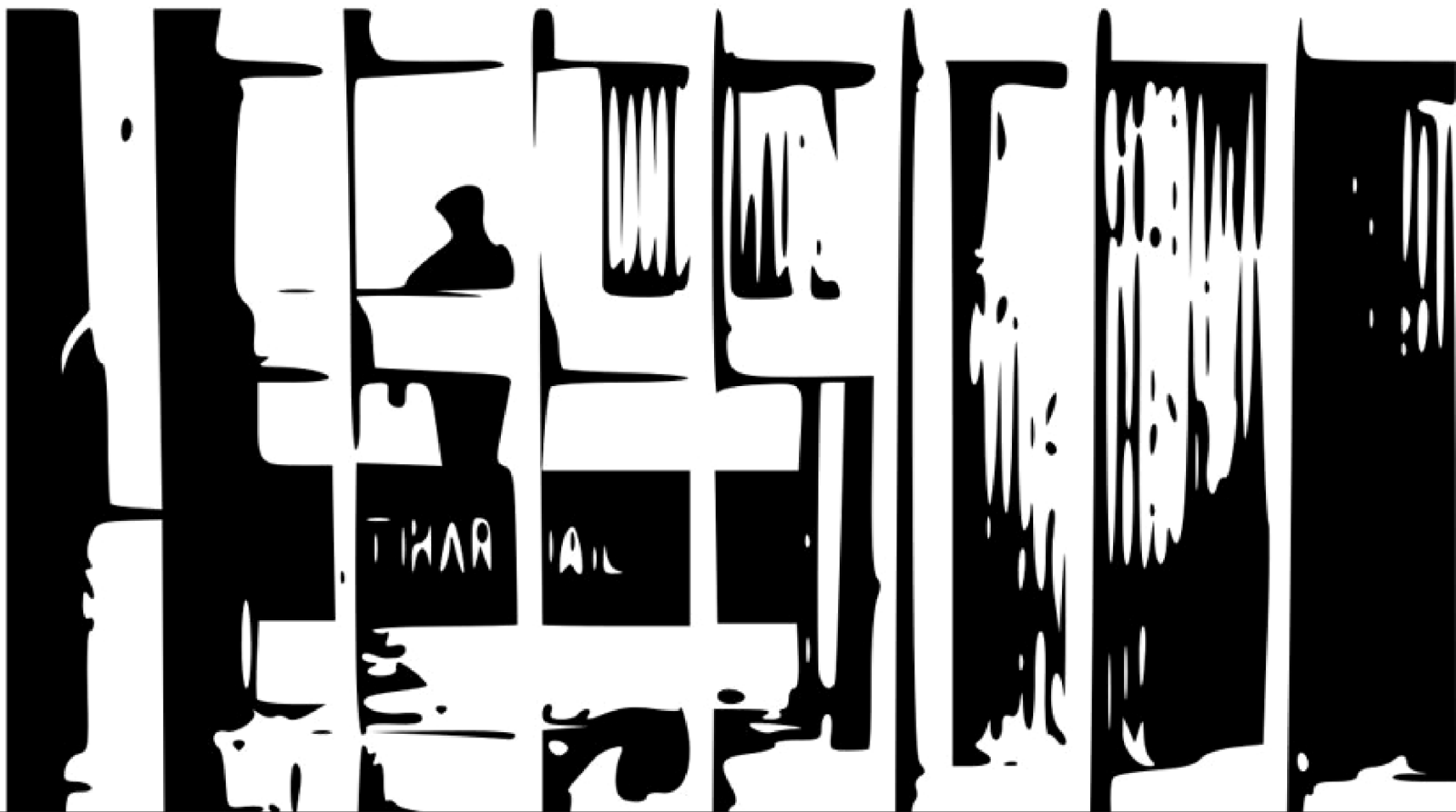
Ek Waqt ki Namaaz

A seven-panel illustrated essay by journalist and activist Firaag — written from the experience of his own arrests at the India Gate and JNU Long March protests — on Sharjeel Imam's return to Tihar jail, and what it means to witness the state's appetite for detention from inside a cell. Illustrated by Mouli Sharma.

BY FIRAAQ

Ki Namaaz

Thoughts on Sharjeel Imam and freedom.



When I was in Tihar, I had a conversation with a Muslim jailmate from UP, about Sharjeel Imam. He said, “*Hamare gaaon me hum sab log har roz ek waqt ki namaaz Sharjeel bhai ke liye padhte hai.*”

That day, I realised just what it is that Sharjeel has earned.

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I believe history will remember Sharjeel for two things:

First, how a young Muslim man came forward and reached out to his community, and organised one of the biggest mass movements against an Islamophobic, fascist state, earning love and respect from his own people.



Second, how this same Islamophobic fascist state, the Indian state, tried to suppress his voice. Just a young man asking for his community's right to exist.



Today, Sharjeel will return to Tihar after 10 days spent in his home, among his people; 10 days in his village, on his land - free. I have to admit, this time it feels a little more personal.

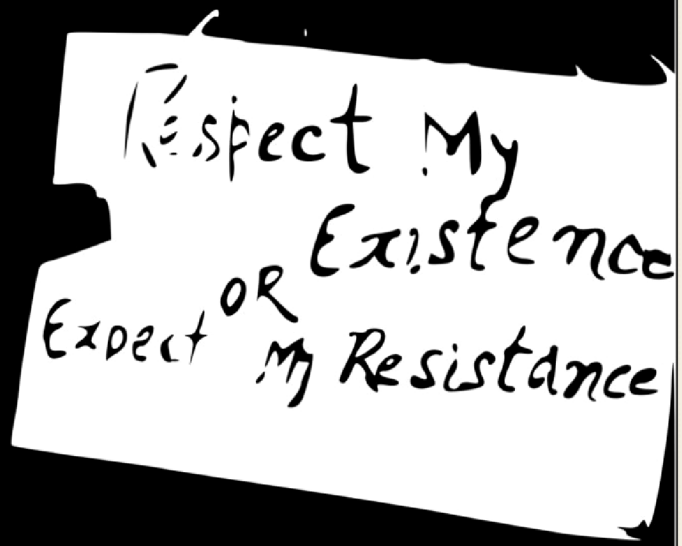
But that's the catch, isn't it?

At the end of it all, the
Indian state has failed.

The state failed to
suppress Sharjeel's spirit;
perhaps more
importantly, the state
also failed to suppress
the love and respect
people have for their
Sharjeel bhai.



History will be kind
to you, Sharjeel.
Because those who
are writing it now
will not get to tell
yours.



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